

Why Doesn't MIDI Work On My PC?

MIDI stands for Musical Instrument Digital Interface, a standard adopted by the electronic music industry for controlling devices such as synthesisers and sound cards that emit music. This article helps readers to solve the problem of MIDI files not playing on a PC.



MIDI is a wonderful standard that defines the protocols and interfaces for electronic musical instruments and computers. Nowadays, it is possible to create even large-scale orchestral pieces using just a personal computer. This article covers only standard MIDI files (.smf or .midi or .mid), which contain details like notations for different instruments and act like an audio file when played using a MIDI player. You are probably familiar with MIDI files, since many ring tones and Web music clips come in that format.

What makes MIDI files distinguishable is that their sound is not pre-recorded. The file contains just some notations for different instruments used in that particular piece of music. It is played with the help of a soundfont, which contains pre-recorded sounds for those instruments. This makes MIDI files extremely small. Another advantage of MIDI files is that you can study a piece of music and modify it. There are many programs like *Muscore*, which can convert a given MIDI file to a score sheet and vice versa.

GNU/Linux users do run into difficulties with MIDI files and programs. But many users live with them, believing that the problems can never be solved until a new version is released. Actually, they can be solved in a few very simple

steps. You should try them so you can experience a lot of wonderful MIDI applications in GNU/Linux.

Programs and ports

MIDI is a built-in facility with almost all GNU/Linux distros. But do ensure that you have the *TiMidity++* MIDI Sequencer installed in your system (we are not considering other sequencers now). So let us solve some MIDI problems.

Playback

Most users find it difficult to open a MIDI file. Some players don't support them. For example, VLC needs an additional *FluidSynth* plugin to read them. You can solve this problem by installing appropriate plugins using the Synaptic Package Manager, the *apt-get install* command or any other package manager.

Some players won't play MIDI files properly. For example, Totem plays MIDI files in a discrete manner. *TiMidity++* is a better option. Always right click on a MIDI file and select *TiMidity++* from the *Open With* sub-menu options.

The command line program *timidity* also offers many features. See the command below, which plays a MIDI file with 200 per cent volume and 150 per cent tempo.